

**Replacing trees** with human settlements destabilizes the soil on slopes, and mudslides, such as this catastrophic event in Sierra Leone in 2017, are more likely to occur.

**“I became an ecologist long before I had ever heard the word.”**

**Chico Mendes**

## Fueling global warming

Burning wood or forests adds carbon dioxide ($CO_2$) to the atmosphere. By contrast, living plants of all kinds reduce $CO_2$, as they absorb carbon, taking up the greenhouse gas to perform photosynthesis, thus countering the damaging impact of human activities. Globally, forests suck up 2.65 billion tons (2.4 billion tonnes) of $CO_2$ every year. Environmentalists and climatologists worry that removing large tracts of tropical forest could be disastrous.